Lesson 18: Reading Profiles 2: Gibson and Valdez

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You

Adapted from Getting to Know You - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA): 1.4: Reading: Profile Gibson; 1.5: Reading: Profile Valdez.

In this lesson

You will read two student profiles: Cody Gibson, who maps the ocean floor, and Felipe Valdez, a NASA intern who moved from Mexico to the U.S. You will skim for facts, ask yourself questions while you read, write the interview questions behind a profile, and find past tense verbs and time signal words.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Skim a profile for key facts, and make "person" nouns with -er and -or (photographer).
- Ask and answer questions after each paragraph to understand a difficult text.
- Write the interview questions that a profile writer probably asked.
- Find simple past verbs and time signals (In 2007, After high school, then).

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
geography	the study of the earth: land, water, people, resources and industries	We know more about the moon's geography than the sea floor's.
hydrography	the science of mapping seas, lakes and rivers	Hydrography keeps him out on the water in summer.
survey (v)	examine and record an area to make a map	In summer he is out on the water, surveying.
adventure	an unusual and exciting activity or experience	Alaska sounded like the best adventure.
in high demand	many employers want these people	Geomatics graduates are in high demand in Alaska.
intern	a student who works for an organization for a short time to learn	Felipe Valdez is a NASA intern.
at a crossroads	at a moment when you must make an important choice	At the time, his life was at a crossroads.
pursue	try to get or do something over a long time	He moved to the U.S. to pursue his education.
excel	do very well	Felipe excelled in all his courses.

Rules and explanations

Skimming

Skim = read very fast for the main facts: names, places, titles. Look at the title, the first lines, the photos and the captions.

Words for people: -er and -or

- geography → geographer; photography → photographer; hydrography → hydrographer (take away -y, add -er)
- adventure → adventurer (the word ends in -e: add -r)
- travel → traveler (American spelling; British: traveller)
- survey → surveyor (add -or)

Questioning while you read

When a text is difficult, stop after each paragraph and ask yourself questions (Who? What? Where? When? Why?). Answer them before you go on.

From answer to interview question

A profile writer interviews the person first. Look at the answer, then write the question. Use the same tense as the answer.

- "I work for Fugro Pelagos." (present) → Where do you work?
- "My mom just liked to travel a lot." (past) → Why did you go to so many schools?
- Pattern: question word + do/does/did + subject + base verb.

Past tense and time signals

- Most verbs in Felipe's story are **simple past** because the events are finished: moved, made, started, excelled, graduated, began, attended, received, became.
- The first sentence uses the **present simple** because it is a general fact: "Many students move away from home when they start college."
- **Time signals** show when each event happened: In 2007, At the time, After moving to California, After high school, first, then, During his time at Sacramento State. They help **cohesion and coherence** (the connection of ideas in sentences and in the whole text). Without them (Passage Two in your material), the text is repetitive and harder to follow.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - In Arabic the verb can come before the subject. In English statements, the subject comes first ("Felipe moved to California"). In questions, the helping verb comes before the subject ("When did Felipe move to California?").

Practice

1. Skim (Gibson). Skim the profile "Student Spotlight--Cody Gibson" for 30 seconds. Write: the student's name, his major, the name of the profile author, the name of the university.

2. Vocabulary. Match the words with the meanings. Then add -er or -or to make a word for a person. Words: 1 geography; 2 photography; 3 adventure; 4 survey; 5 travel; 6 hydrography a) the science of mapping bodies of water, such as seas, lakes, and rivers; b) the study of the physical features of the earth as well as populations, resources, land use, and industries; c) to make a journey; to go from one place to another; d) the art of taking and processing photographs; e) to examine and record an area in order to make a map; f) an unusual and exciting activity or experience Then complete the book's sentences for each meaning a) to f): "A _____ is a person who studies the science of mapping bodies of water..." (a), "A _____ is a person who studies the physical features of the earth..." (b), and so on.

3. Gibson: comprehension. Read the profile again. a) What company does Cody work for and what do they do? b) Which defines "mapping"? Putting locations on a map / Sleeping peacefully in the afternoon / Wearing an orange vest around campus c) When will Cody graduate? Where will he work after he graduates? d) What subject did Cody study before he came to the University of Alaska? e) What are some advantages of studying geomatics, according to the profile? Choose all that apply: Jobs in geomatics are easy to find / Geomatics is an easy major / The professors are very nice and helpful / The jobs in geomatics offer interesting travel / Geomatics technology is interesting / People who work in geomatics are active

4. Writing interview questions (Gibson). For each answer, write the question the interviewer probably asked Cody. Start with the word given.

1. I work for Fugro Pelagos, a company with surveyors around the world who specialize in mapping the seafloor. Question: Where do you work? (example)
2. Essentially, we're mapping the Earth, using math, physics, law practices, everything possible. What...?
3. I first connected with Fugro Pelagos as an intern two years ago. How...?
4. University of Alaska, Anchorage is my 17th school since I was in first grade. Where...?
5. My mom just liked to travel a lot so we traveled often. Why...?
6. I started at Southern Oregon University; then I attended University of Colorado. Where...?
7. Alaska sounded like the best adventure. Why...?
8. I enjoy solo kayaking adventures, hiking, and biking. I always take my camera. Why...?
9. Read the last part of the profile, from "If all goes to plan...". Write one open-ended question that the interviewer asked to learn this information.

5. Valdez: guided reading. Before you read, skim the photos and captions of "Felipe Valdez: Life at a Crossroads" for 30 seconds: who is the article about? Then read, stop after each paragraph and answer.

- Paragraph 1: a) Where is Felipe Valdez from? b) Why did he decide to move?
- Paragraph 2: c) Where did Felipe go to high school? d) Was he successful? Find the clause that gives you the answer.
- Paragraph 3: e) Where did Felipe start college? f) Where did he finish college? g) What awards has he won? What subjects is he good at?
- Paragraph 4: h) Where is Felipe studying now? i) Who is mentoring him?

- Paragraph 5: j) What is the name of the space vehicle Felipe is working on? k) This paragraph is difficult. Which words do you understand? What is the general idea of his project?
- Paragraph 6: l) What is he trying to improve on the vehicle?
- Paragraphs 7 and 8: m) Who is speaking in each paragraph with quotation marks?

6. Valdez: rhetorical analysis. a) This profile is most likely found: in a national newspaper / on the NASA website about interns / on the National Parks website about volunteers / on the Facebook dating website b) The purpose is: to convince the reader to donate money to NASA / to convince the reader that their taxes are well spent at NASA / to inform the reader about different programs at NASA / to inform the reader about different colleges in California. What other purposes could it have? Discuss with your tutor. c) What information is not included? Felipe's educational accomplishments / Felipe's immigration history / Felipe's projects at NASA / Quotes that praise Felipe and his mentor / Information about Felipe's family

7. Past tense verbs. In Passage One (the first three paragraphs), underline all the verbs. Most are simple past. Why? A few are not. Which ones, and why?

8. Signals for cohesion. Fill in the 15 gaps in "Passage Two--Revised" with words from Passage One. Number the gaps 1 to 15 in your printed copy first. (Gaps 8 and 11 each have two lines; gap 10 is the start of the word "_irst".)

Speak with your tutor

- "You are Cody Gibson. I am a journalist. I will ask you my interview questions from exercise 4. Answer like Cody, and correct my questions if they are wrong."
- "You are Felipe Valdez. I will interview you about your past: leaving Mexico, high school, college and NASA. I must use past tense questions (When did you...? Why did you...?). Correct my grammar."
- "Let me retell Felipe's story in 8 sentences with time signals: In 2007, After moving, After high school, Then, During his time at... Check my past tense verbs."
- "Tell me about an adventure you had. Then I will ask you 5 open-ended questions about it. Tell me which of my questions was the best."

Read aloud

1. ge·OG·ra·phy, ge·OG·ra·pher
2. pho·TOG·ra·phy, pho·TOG·ra·pher
3. ad·VEN·ture, ad·VEN·tur·er
4. sur·VEY·or, TRAV·el·er, IN·tern·ship, me·CHAN·i·cal
5. Where do you work? (↘)
6. Why did you decide to come to Alaska? (↘)
7. Was he successful? (↗)

Answer key

1. Cody Gibson; geomatics; Jamie Gonzales (the book's questions spell it "Gonzalez"); University of Alaska, Anchorage (UAA).

2. 1 b; 2 d; 3 f; 4 e; 5 c; 6 a. Sentences: a) hydrographer; b) geographer; c) traveler; d) photographer; e) surveyor; f) adventurer.

3. a) Fugro Pelagos, a company with surveyors around the world who specialize in mapping the sea floor. b) Putting locations on a map. c) In December (he has one semester left). He will work full-time for Fugro. d) Photography. e) Jobs in geomatics are easy to find; the jobs offer interesting travel; geomatics technology is interesting.

4. (example answers; other questions are possible) 1 Where do you work? (book) 2 What does a person studying geomatics do? 3 How did you first connect with Fugro Pelagos? 4 Where do you go to school now? 5 Why did you go to so many schools? 6 Where did you study before UAA? 7 Why did you decide to come to Alaska? 8 Why do you love living in Alaska? 9 What are your plans for the future?

5. Felipe Valdez, a NASA intern. a) Mexico. b) To pursue his education and career: in the U.S. he could continue his education. c) River Valley High School in Yuba City, California. d) Yes: "Felipe excelled in all his courses and graduated with an excellent GPA." e) Yuba Community College. f) California State University, Sacramento. g) The Extended Opportunity Programs & Services Student Role Model award and the Mathematics, Engineering, and Science Achievement Student of the Year award; also several scholarships. He is good at mathematics, engineering and science. h) California State University, Sacramento: he is a mechanical engineering graduate student. i) Dr. Jose Granda, his professor. j) Morpheus. k) (example answer) He designed a control system so the vehicle can go straight up and down and stay in the right position. l) Its control system: he wants the vehicle to do complex maneuvers autonomously (by itself). m) First: Oscar Murillo, his NASA mentor. Second: Felipe Valdez.

6. a) On the NASA website about interns. b) (best answer; discuss) To convince the reader that their taxes are well spent at NASA. Other possible purposes: to encourage students to study STEM or to apply for NASA internships. c) Information about Felipe's family.

7. Simple past, because the events are finished: moved, made, was, started, excelled, graduated, began, attended, received, went on, became, was invited (past passive). Not simple past: "move" and "start" in the first two sentences (present simple: a general fact about students); "could stay / leave / find / move / have" (could + base verb: possible choices at that time); infinitives (to leave, to pursue, to continue, to work, to study, to join) and -ing forms (moving, integrating, learning, earning, graduating).

8. 1 While; 2 In 2007; 3 and; 4 At the time; 5 or; 6 After moving; 7 about an; 8 Despite the challenge of integrating into a new culture and learning a new language; 9 After high school; 10 first; 11 where, in addition to earning his associate degree and graduating with honors,; 12 then; 13 where he; 14 During his time at Sacramento State; 15 also.

My notes